

English
Book Two
For the class XII

Ulysses

by

Alfred Lord Tennyson



<i>Name</i>	Alfred Lord Tennyson
<i>Born & died</i>	1809-1892
<i>Place of birth</i>	England
<i>Profession</i>	Poet
<i>Period</i>	Victorian
<i>Written</i>	In blank verse

<i>Type of work</i>	<i>Inspirational</i>
<i>Theme</i>	To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield
<i>Tone</i>	determined, reflective, and inspirational

Short Question Answers

Q 1- How did Ulysses inspire his mariners to embark on a new journey?

OR

Describe how Ulysses inspires his sailors to embark a new adventure?

OR

How does Ulysses motivate his companion to sail once again? And why?

Ans. In Ulysses by Alfred Lord Tennyson, Ulysses inspires his mariners by reminding them of their past adventures and encouraging them to seek new experiences despite their old age. He urges them to remain strong, saying, **“To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield.”** Ulysses tells them they are “not now that strength” of youth but still have **“heroic hearts.”** He calls them to sail beyond the sunset, embracing courage and perseverance in their final journey.

Q 2- What does Ulysses mean by the following lines?

Made weak by time and fate but strong in will

To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield.

Ans. Ulysses acknowledges that he and his mariners have grown weak due to time and fate. However, he emphasizes that their willpower remains strong. He encourages them to keep striving, exploring, and discovering, no matter the challenges. The famous line "To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield" means never giving up, always pushing forward, and facing life's struggles with courage. Ulysses inspires them to pursue greatness until the end.

Q 3. What moral does the poem “Ulysses” teach us?

OR

What message did Ulysses give to his mariners?

Ans. The poem Ulysses by Alfred Lord Tennyson teaches us the moral of perseverance, courage, and lifelong learning. Ulysses refuses to settle into a quiet life and instead seeks new adventures, showing that one should always strive for growth. The line **“To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield”** teaches us to keep moving forward despite challenges. The poem inspires us to stay strong, embrace new experiences, and never stop chasing our goals, no matter our age.

Q 4. Explain the assertion that Ulysses is a symbol of adventurous spirit.

Ans. In the poem “Ulysses” by Alfred Lord Tennyson, Ulysses represents the adventurous spirit because he refuses to live a dull, idle life. Instead of staying in comfort, he longs for the unknown, saying, **“I cannot rest from travel.”** He sees life as a journey, always pushing beyond limits. His call to sail **“beyond the sunset”** shows his fearless curiosity. Ulysses symbolizes those who chase dreams, embrace challenges, and never let age or fate stop them from seeking new horizons.

“Life is either a great adventure or nothing.”- Helen Keller

Q 5. How does Ulysses’ reflection on death (“Death close all”) shape his perspective on life and action?

Ans. In Alfred Lord Tennyson’s “*Ulysses*,” the line “Death closes all” reflects Ulysses’ awareness of life’s inevitable end, yet it fuels his desire for continual striving. Instead of surrendering to old age or comfort, he views mortality as a reason to act with greater purpose. Death, to him, is not a defeat but a reminder that time is limited and must be used meaningfully. This realization transforms his outlook—he chooses adventure, knowledge, and heroic pursuit over stagnation, seeking to live fully until life’s final moment.

Q 6. What theme related to perseverance and the human spirit emerge in Ulysses speech?

Ans. In Tennyson’s “*Ulysses*,” the theme of perseverance and the strength of the human spirit is shown through Ulysses’ desire to keep moving forward despite age and hardship. He refuses to accept a quiet or inactive life and believes that the true purpose of living is to seek new experiences and challenges. His speech shows that courage, curiosity, and determination can keep the human spirit alive even when the body grows old. Ulysses inspires others to strive, explore, and never give up until the end of life.

Q 7. What does Ulysses’ words “T is not too late to seek a newer world” mean?

Ans. In Tennyson’s “*Ulysses*,” the words “‘Tis not too late to seek a newer world” mean that it is never too late to start something new or to chase one’s dreams. Even though Ulysses is old, he still believes that life has more to offer and that exploration and discovery should never stop. His words show hope, courage, and the belief that human spirit and ambition can overcome age or limits. He wants to inspire others to keep seeking purpose and adventure, no matter how late in life it may seem.

Q 8. What does “Happy Isle” symbolize in the poem?

Ans. In the poem “*Ulysses*” the “Happy Isle” symbolizes the final journey of life, possibly representing death or the afterlife. It is seen as a peaceful and distant place where Ulysses hopes to reach through his last adventure. Rather than fearing death, he views it as a continuation of his quest for knowledge and meaning. The “Happy Isle” also stands for eternal rest, fulfillment, and the hope of reunion with his old comrades. It shows Ulysses’ brave and positive attitude toward life’s end and the unknown beyond it.

Critical Review:

The poem "Ulysses" by Alfred, Lord Tennyson is about an old king, Ulysses, who refuses to rest and wants to keep exploring. He feels restless after returning home from his adventures and believes that life should be lived with courage and purpose. The poem encourages people to keep striving, no matter their age or challenges. It has a strong and inspiring tone, showing the human spirit's desire for knowledge and growth. Ulysses' famous words, "*To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield,*" remind us to never give up and always aim for greatness. However, some critics argue that Ulysses is **too self-centered**, as he neglects his duties as a king.

Figure of speech from the poem "Ulysses" along with examples



1- Symbolism

In poem: "The Happy Isles"

– Symbolizes heaven or the final resting place after death.

In sentence: *He dreamed of a happy isle beyond life's troubles.*

2- Hyperbole

In poem: "To sail beyond the sunset."

– Exaggerates his longing to explore beyond human limits.

In sentence: *She promised to love him till the stars fell from the sky.*

3- Imagery

In poem: "The lights begin to twinkle from the rocks."

– Creates a vivid picture of a fading evening scene.

In sentence: *Golden rays danced across the calm blue sea.*

4- Alliteration

In poem: "heroic hearts"

— Reflects courage and spirit, and the alliteration enhances its emotional and rhythmic power.

In sentence: Her heroic heart helped her rise after every fall.

Meanings and Synonyms of Difficult Words and Phrases (Glossary) from the poem “Ulysses”.



1. **Abide** – To accept or endure something; to remain or stay.
Synonyms: tolerate, endure, withstand, remain
2. **Achilles** – A famous Greek hero of the Trojan War known for his strength and bravery.
Synonyms: warrior, champion, hero
3. **Ere** – An old poetic word meaning *before*.
Synonyms: before, prior to, earlier than
4. **Furrows** – Long, narrow trenches made in the ground by a plow; also used metaphorically for wrinkles or lines.
Synonyms: grooves, trenches, ruts
5. **Gulfs** – Deep, wide spaces or divisions; large areas of sea partly enclosed by land.
Synonyms: chasms, abysses, gaps, voids
6. **Happy Isles** – Mythical islands in Greek legend where heroes go after death, symbolizing heaven or eternal peace.
Synonyms: paradise, heaven, afterlife
7. **Moans** – Low sounds expressing pain or sadness.
Synonyms: groans, laments, cries, wails
8. **Move heaven to earth** – To try to do something impossible or extremely difficult.
Synonyms: attempt the impossible, make every effort, go to great lengths
9. **Seek** – To look for or try to find something.
Synonyms: search, pursue, strive for, endeavor
10. **Strive** – To make great efforts to achieve or obtain something.
Synonyms: struggle, endeavor, fight, attempt

11. Thunder – A loud rumbling noise caused by lightning; also used to describe loud, powerful sounds or speech.

Synonyms: roar, rumble, boom

12. Toil – Hard or exhausting work.

Synonyms: labor, drudgery, exertion, effort, strive

13. Unbecoming – Not appropriate or suitable; improper.

Synonyms: inappropriate, improper, unsuitable, indecent

14. Wane – To decrease in strength, power, or intensity; to fade.

Synonyms: diminish, decline, weaken, fade

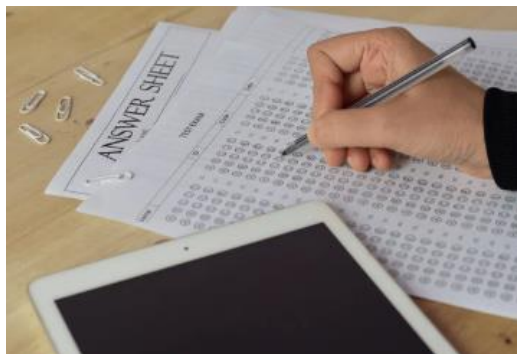
15. Wrought – (Old form of *worked*) – shaped, created, or formed by effort or skill.

Synonyms: fashioned, formed, crafted, produced

16. Yield – To give way or submit; to produce or provide something.

Synonyms: surrender, submit, give in, produce

Relevant MCQs



1. What is the central theme of the poem *Ulysses*?

- a) The power of nature over humans
- b) The importance of seeking new adventures
- c) The necessity of war and conquest
- d) The struggles of old age

2. Who is the speaker in the poem?

- a) Tennyson himself
- b) Ulysses
- c) Telemachus
- d) The mariners

3. What does Ulysses think about his current life as a king?

- a) He enjoys ruling Ithaca and finds it fulfilling
- b) He considers it a waste of his abilities and desires adventure
- c) He fears losing power over his people
- d) He believes Ithaca is the best place to retire

4. What does the line “To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield” suggest?

- a) Acceptance of old age and limitations
- b) Continuous effort and perseverance
- c) The importance of resting after hard work
- d) The idea that fate controls everything

5. Which literary device is used in “To strive, to seek”?

- a) Metaphor
- b) Alliteration
- c) Hyperbole
- d) Personification

6. How does Ulysses describe his mariners?

- a) As weak and fearful
- b) As old yet determined
- c) As inexperienced travelers
- d) As enemies from the past

7. What does Ulysses compare his past experiences to?

- a) A sinking ship
- b) A never-ending storm
- c) An arch through which the world appears
- d) A closed book

8. What does the phrase “the long day wanes” symbolize?

- a) The end of a battle
- b) The approach of death or old age
- c) The passing of a storm
- d) The loss of Ithaca’s power

9. Why does Ulysses want to embark on another journey?

- a) He seeks fame and power
- b) He wants to escape from his responsibilities
- c) He craves adventure and new experiences
- d) He wishes to find a new home

10. What does Ulysses mean by “Made weak by time and fate, but strong in will”?

- a) He acknowledges aging but still has a determined spirit
- b) He regrets wasting his youth
- c) He blames fate for his hardships
- d) He believes he has become physically stronger

11. What is the mood of the poem?

- a) Resigned and sorrowful
- b) Hopeful and determined
- c) Angry and rebellious
- d) Fearful and uncertain

12. What is the significance of Ulysses' speech in the poem?

- a) It serves as a farewell to his mariners
- b) It reflects his dissatisfaction with his life and desire for more
- c) It highlights the importance of Ithaca's politics
- d) It warns of the dangers of the sea

Answer key with justifications

1.

Answer: (b) The importance of seeking new adventures

 **Justification:** The poem highlights Ulysses' desire to continue exploring and seeking new experiences, rather than settling into a life of inactivity.

2.

Answer: (b) Ulysses

 **Justification:** The poem is a dramatic monologue where Ulysses expresses his thoughts and desires about life, adventure, and leadership.

3.

Answer: (b) He considers it a waste of his abilities and desires adventure

 **Justification:** Ulysses finds ruling Ithaca monotonous and longs for excitement, as seen in lines like *"How dull it is to pause, to make an end."*

4.

Answer: (b) Continuous effort and perseverance

 **Justification:** This famous line conveys Ulysses' unwavering determination to keep exploring and achieving despite challenges.

5.

Answer: (b) Alliteration

 **Justification:** **"To strive, to seek"** Repetition of consonant sounds at the beginning of words. The repetition of "t" and "s" sounds adds rhythm.

6.

Answer: (b) As old yet determined

 **Justification:** Ulysses acknowledges that they have grown old, but he still believes they have the spirit to embark on one final adventure.

7.

Answer: (c) An arch through which the world appears

 **Justification:** Ulysses describes his past experiences as an arch, symbolizing the way they open up new horizons for him.

8.

Answer: (b) The approach of death or old age

 **Justification:** Ulysses uses this phrase to indicate that time is passing and he is nearing the end of his life.

9.

Answer: (c) He craves adventure and new experiences

 **Justification:** Ulysses believes that life should be lived to the fullest and prefers exploration over stagnation.

10.

Answer: (a) He acknowledges aging but still has a determined spirit

 **Justification:** Ulysses admits that time has weakened him physically, but his inner strength and desire remain.

11.

Answer: (b) Hopeful and determined

 **Justification:** Despite acknowledging his old age, Ulysses remains hopeful and eager to continue his adventures.

12.

Answer: (b) It reflects his dissatisfaction with his life and desire for more

 **Justification:** Ulysses' speech is a reflection of his restless spirit and unwillingness to settle for a mundane life.

The End of the Poem

